

Momentum Investments Retirement Plan: Sales Email

Last summer, you interned with several other college students at Momentum Investments, a financial services firm in San Francisco specializing in retirement accounts for niche client groups. While other investment firms pursue clients with a higher net-worth, Momentum specializes in identifying, contacting and courting a greater number of small investors in niche groups, relying on strong customer service to retain those customers.

Momentum has identified college students as one of those groups it would like to attract for its financial services. Anna Lowe, your supervisor, is the Marketing and Business Development Manager at Momentum; she has started a campaign to market Momentum’s retirement plans to students at select public universities in California, including SDSU.

During your internship last summer, your team helped her develop a marketing strategy to reach students; you came up with the idea of asking her to give very general presentations to student clubs about retirement. These presentations could identify college students as potential Momentum clients. She liked the idea, and suggested you set up presentations at SDSU during the spring semester. She has arranged for Momentum to pay you a recruitment commission based on the number of students you contact.

Anna presented to two student business organizations last month. At the end of her presentation, she had students write down their email address if they would like more information about why they should think about starting a retirement plan. She has collected the addresses, and now wants you to contact the interested students and begin a conversation that will eventually lead to those students signing up with a Momentum retirement plan.

Task

She has asked you to write a generic “permission-based” email message (p. 167) to one of the students on her list. Call him or her Student X. You will use this email as a “boilerplate” template to be modified for future students who signed up for information. Feel free to be creative with details.

You’ll also need to do some quick research online about the benefits of starting a retirement account early. See the “Content” criterion in the “Persuasive Message Rubric.” Spend an hour or so learning about options and benefits before you begin to draft the message. No need to provide citations in the email unless you think it would help your credibility.

Remember, your job here is simply to argue for the need for a retirement plan for students. You don’t need to give particulars about any Momentum plan. This is just your first contact informing a typical SDSU student about the importance of planning for retirement and trying to convince a student to meet and discuss particular plans. You might want to summarize what the students heard in the original presentation in order to ease into the discussion of the content.

Message Goals

The email has three goals:

1. It thanks the student for attending the presentation
2. It convinces him or her that it’s not too early to think about retirement
3. It asks him or her for a future meeting to discuss more options.

Guidelines

You might follow these guidelines as you draft the email message:

- Make sure you understand your reader
- Choose an appropriate combination of strategies that will best appeal to that audience
- Create an opening using that appeal that gains the reader’s attention
- Build your case using research about the importance of planning early for retirement
- Drive toward the next objective, a meeting, possibly to discuss Momentum retirement plans

Resources

You’ll find a discussion of each guideline listed above in our text. Review the “General Advice about Persuasion” section beginning on page 158 first, then focus on the “Sales Messages” section beginning on page 164, including all sample messages presented and discussed in that section.

Contact Information

Use your campus email address for the email, provide a date, and make up a fake email address for Student X. Also, don’t forget to provide an appropriate subject line for the email (see p. 172).